MOUNTAIN REVIEW

OFFICIAL NEWSLETTER OF THE MOUNTAIN VIEW HISTORICAL ASSOCIATION

Volume XI Issue II Spring 2021



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RENGSTORFF HOUSE

Thirty Years of Beauty: Transformed!

OUR SPRING 2021 EVENT

Join us as we celebrate the 30th anniversary of the Rengstorff House's restoration! Built in 1867, the Rengstorff House is the oldest structure still standing in Mountain View. The ornate Italianate Victorian house, now located in Shoreline Park, was fully restored in 1991 thanks to the hard work of dedicated local residents, City staff, and civic leaders who fought the odds to save it from demolition.

Our panel discussion will feature guest speakers from the group that helped save the Rengstorff House, the "Friends of "R" House," and staff from the City of Mountain View—Shoreline Division who will share images and recount stories of the house's fascinating history. For a preview of some of the stories you'll hear, check out page 6 of the newsletter. We hope to see you there!

REGISTER AT:

http://mvhistory.eventbrite.com

CO-HOSTED BY:

RENGSTORFF HOUSE
Built 1867 Restored 1990
Friends of "R" House
Incorporated 1992

SHORELINE AT·MOUNTAIN·VIEW

SUNDAY, MAY 2, 2021 ● 1:00 P.M. TO 2:30 P.M. ● FREE ZOOM WEBINAR

This newsletter is published four times a year by the
MOUNTAIN VIEW HISTORICAL ASSOCIATION
P.O. Box 252, Mountain View, CA 94042
www.mountainviewhistorical.org

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News & Notes

President's Message

By Pamela Baird
MVHA President


Pamela Baird

Write it down! When I was doing research for the suffrage exhibit at the Los Altos History Museum and the presentation shown at the November MVHA general meeting one thought kept occurring to me. Wouldn't it be great if we could find a memoir or diary of a MV woman who actually participated in the suffrage efforts in 1911? If it hadn't been for the newspapers kept in the history center at the MV Library (for which I am really grateful!) there wouldn't have been much of a story to tell. But it would have been so much more interesting to have a first-person account of the many events in which local women participated.

And this brings me to today and the stressful, crazy and historic time that we all have been experiencing during COVID. I started writing a "COVID Chronicles" over a year ago. Its primary purpose was to document where and when my husband and I ventured out to shop in case either of us became ill. I quickly expanded my comments to include observations of people's behavior, Zoom calls with family, things we saw on our walks, current events and the status of the pandemic. I also documented the daily totals of COVID cases worldwide, nationally and the US death toll.

Some of the entries are quite boring and repetitious, but that's what life quickly became. I write about what meals I prepared (food preparation and its consumption has become a focal point of the average day) and how the tomato plants were or were not growing.

I write in the COVID Chronicles every day, usually about a half page in length. Some evenings (I do this just before I go to bed) it's a struggle to think of something to write but, I feel that it's important to keep at it.

Amy Ellison, the exhibition curator at the Los Altos History Museum (and the other speaker at the November meeting) wrote last spring to members of the Museum to encourage writing memories of the COVID pandemic. I sent her an email about my chronicle writing and how I felt my entries would be boring to future readers. She wrote back the following "That's fantastic that you're keeping such a detailed journal. I can tell you from experience that will not be boring at all to historians. A source like that that can sometimes make a historian's career!"

The Los Altos History Museum is soliciting contributions of COVID writings, memoirs, and materials. Their goal is "collecting our community's experiences and preserving this history for future generations." Learn more at www.losaltoshistory.org/documenting-covid-19-in-santa-clara-county .

The Board of Mountain View Historical Association is considering how we can develop a similar program. Watch for an announcement in the next month or two.

Will my efforts be of interest to someone in the future? Maybe. Who knows? But I know if I don't do this, potential future readers will have no idea of our day to day life during the pandemic days of 2020 and 2021.

—Pamela

Financial Report

By Emily Ramos
MVHA Treasurer

Checking Account Balance as of 1/17/2021: $21,195.97
Income: $473.28
Expenses: $411.80
Checking Account Balance as of 3/31/2021: $21,257.45

Certificates of Deposit Balance as of 1/17/2021: $60,476.67
Certificates of Deposit Balance as of 3/31/2021: $60,519.62

New to the Archives

By Nicholas Perry
MVHA Past President

Thanks to the thoughtful donations of folks who have connected with us via our social media, we have some wonderful new historical items to add to our archives once they reopen (hopefully soon! For now, they're stored in my garage).

Jon Anderson, a former Mountain View resident (MVHS Class of 1975) who now lives in Australia, mailed us some treasured items he wanted to ensure would be appreciated more than they might be if they stayed down under. They include:

-A vintage 15" by 20" aerial photograph of NASA Ames Research Center

-A program from a Whisman School student play *The Unbeautiful Princess*

-Class photos spanning his years at Theuerkauf, Whisman, and Saint Joseph elementary schools from 1963 through 1969

Jim Pedersen sent us a great collection of items from his family's collection. Jim's parents, LeRoy F. Pedersen and Jeanne E. (Parmentier) Pedersen, moved to Mtn. View from Takoma Park, Maryland, in 1948 so LeRoy could take a job at Pacific Press on Villa Street. Jim sent us the following:

-18 black-and-white snapshots showing parades in Downtown Mountain View, circa 1949

-A collection of postcards depicting the Pacific Press campus on Villa Street

-Digital copies of photos of his family's first home in Mountain View, on Villa Street

At our last board meeting, the MVHA discussed developing procedures for collecting and accepting digital donations into our archives. Stay tuned for more information on that topic.

As always, if you have items you would like to donate to our archive, please email us at info@mountainviewhistorical.org with a short description of the item. Or, contact us via our Facebook page at www.facebook.com/MVHistory .

you needed a copy editor.

Cynthia Hanson
Editorial Consultant & Copy Editor

Whether you're updating your resume or writing the world's next great novel, Cynthia Hanson is available to help make sure your writing is clear and typo-free. As the MVHA's volunteer copy editor, she's helped make this newsletter shine and is available to hire for other projects.

Contact Cynthia today:
cynthialynnhanson@gmail.com

MVHS Monument

By Mark Perry
MVHA Ways & Means Committee Chair

At our winter 2021 Board of Directors meeting, the MVHA Board was excited to welcome Alberto Olmos, vice chair of the Mountain View High School Monument Committee (MVHMC). As reported in previous newsletters, the MVHMC is working to create a monument that recognizes the history and legacy of student athletes of Mountain View High School. The proposed Eagle Park monument would celebrate the 1975 Mountain View High Eagles' football championship, when the school's remarkably diverse, underdog team fought against the odds to beat much larger, wealthier schools and, in the process, brought the Mountain View community together with a shared sense of Eagle pride.

The concept for the proposed monument, which would be located on the school's former athletic fields at Eagle Park, was approved by the City of Mountain View's Parks & Recreation Commission in January 2020. As we begin to emerge from the COVID-19 pandemic, the committee is once again working to move the monument proposal forward.

Given our shared goals of sharing and celebrating the history of Mountain View, the MVHMC has requested to form a partnership with the MVHA on this project. The MVHA Board of Directors is now investigating how to structure the partnership and prepare our organization to potentially serve as the fiscal sponsor for the project. The Board voted to create a subcommittee for this effort, consisting of Lisa Garcia, Nick Perry, Mark Perry, and Emily Ramos. If you're interested in helping with this effort, please contact us at info@mountainviewhistorical.org .



History Happening Now







On Sunday, April 11 a Stop Asian Hate March & Rally took place in Downtown Mountain View. MVHA Board Secretary Jamil Shaikh (upper right photo) was at the march and took photos to include in our archives. For more information on the march, visit https://chrischiang.wixsite.com/aapimv .

Standing with Our Asian American Community

By Nicholas Perry
MVHA Past President

The Mountain View Historical Association Board of Directors stands in solidarity with the Asian American community and all those impacted by recent attacks and hate crimes locally and across the country.

These recent events have highlighted the racism and discrimination that Asian Americans have faced for generations. The Mountain View community has long taken great pride in its diversity, but our city has not been immune to the impacts of racism; from anti-Chinese campaigns in the 1880s, to the internment of our Japanese community during World War II, to other less headline-grabbing acts of discrimination.

Our organization is dedicated to documenting and sharing the history of Mountain View, both the good and the bad. We welcome your thoughts on how we can continue to meet that mission. Fostering a deep understanding of our diverse community's complex history, and learning from the lessons our history offers us, are key to charting a course toward a better, more just future.

NASA Ames Contributes to Mars 2020 Mission

By Pamela Baird
MVHA President

The recent successful landing of the Mars 2020 Perseverance was made in part by the research and ground-breaking technologies developed at the NASA Ames facility at Moffett in Mountain View. The mission of the Perseverance rover is to better understand the climate and geology of Mars and to search for ancient microbial life.

Four key contributions to the mission were made at Ames. According to the NASA website these included entry systems, a thermal protection system, helping the first Mars helicopter fly, and measuring the extreme environment during landing.

These contributions built upon earlier technologies developed at Ames, which led the design, testing and development of thermal protection for the 2012 Curiosity program. Ames participated in the redesign of the Mars 2020 entry parachute, which needed to be strengthened. The wind tunnel on Moffett, which is managed and operated by the US Air Force, is the only facility in the world capable of testing the full-size parachute canopy.

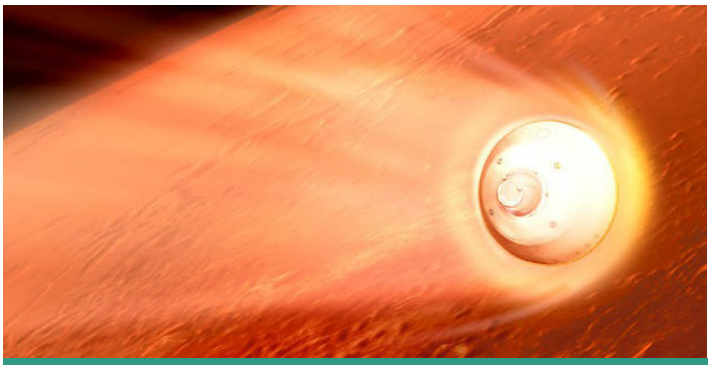


Illustration of NASA's Mars 2020 Perserverance Rover entering the Martian atmosphere. (Source: NASA/JPL-Caltech)

Critical computer modeling and research established that infrared radiation from carbon dioxide is a key contributor to spacecraft heating during Mars entry. Experiments were conducted in the Electric Arc Shock Tube facility at Ames, the only facility in the United States capable of simulating the radiative heating experienced by a spacecraft as it enters an atmosphere at high speed.

More information can be found at:
www.nasa.gov/ames/mars2020

Winter 2021 Event Recap



A well-attended Zoom meeting February 14 provided information about the naming of "Silicon Valley." David Laws, the semiconductor curator for the Computer History Museum, gave an entertaining review of the players and companies that created "Silicon Valley." It was fun to learn (or remember) how these companies and their ground breaking innovations helped create the dynamic area in which we live today. David also spoke about the companies located in the East Whisman area of Mountain View. The link to an article by David is shown here: https://medium.com/chmcore/silicon-valley-turns-fifty-27738a1bf2b0 .

The second half of the program covered the anticipated future of the East Whisman area. Nikki Lowy and Brooke Ray Smith, the community engagement managers for Google's East Whisman project, presented a slide program showing images of future plans. Google is working with the City to totally reimagine and redevelop a sustainable and connected neighborhood, called Middlefield Park. The plans include a new park, residential buildings, retail and office space. Here is the link to the project: https://realestate.withgoogle.com/middlefieldpark .

After the presentations, a Q & A session followed. An interested group of viewers asked many questions, which provided more information about the past and the future of this area of Mountain View.

Remembrances

Editor's Note: Space permitting, the *Mtn. Review* shares remembrances of individuals who played a unique role in Mountain View's history. To submit a remembrance, email us at newsletter@mountainviewhistorical.org.

CORNELIA UTLEY

Cornelia van de Voort Utley, a Mountain View resident since 1988, passed away on March 20 at the age of 92. She became a member of the first Mountain View Visual Arts Committee, which selects unique artwork for installation around the City. The Committee also organized a sand sculpture contest for Mountain View's "Discover Downtown" festival in 1990.

"Neil," as she was known, was a charter member of the Rengstorff House Restoration Committee following its relocation to Shoreline Park. Born in 1928 in Fredonia, NY, Neil developed and maintained an interest in art throughout her life. In 1951 she graduated from the Albright Art School in Buffalo, NY. Two years later she married Charles Utley of Buffalo. The pair lived in East Aurora, NY and welcomed the birth of three sons. Later the family moved to Rochester, NY.

A business opportunity for Charles brought them to Los Altos in 1970. Neil served as an art docent in the Los Altos elementary schools for a number of years. She explained the works of important painters and sculptors to the school children.

Neil was preceded in death by her husband. She is survived by three sons and three grandchildren.

Special Feature:

The Rengstorff House Lives On



The dilapidated and abandoned Rengstorff House as it appeared on Stierlin Road (now Shoreline Boulevard) in 1976 prior its relocation to Shoreline Park. (Photo by Ken Yim, from the MVHA archives)

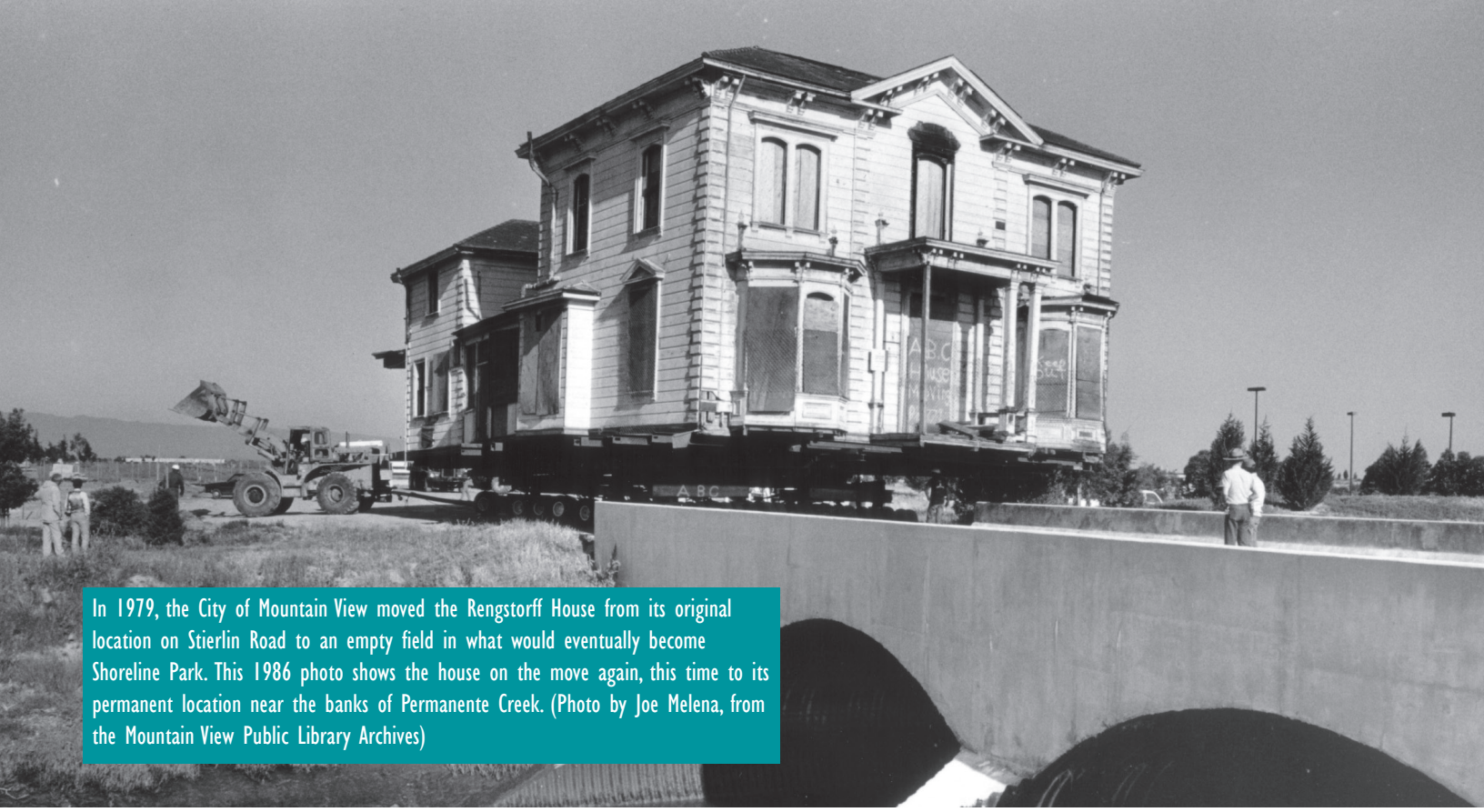
By Martha Wallace
Friends of "R" House Secretary & MVHA Member

The Rengstorff House is Mountain View's oldest home, and a fine example of Victorian Italianate architecture. But do you know the story about its place in Mountain View's past? To discover that story, here is a short account, based on memories and research, about the handsome home and farm, the family that lived there, and a selection of the events leading up to the structure's renovation 30 years ago.

A Prominent Shipper and Agriculturalist. When 21-year-old Henry Rengstorff arrived from Germany in 1850 with $4 in his pocket, panning and mining opportunities in the Gold Rush were limited. However, he learned that there were many opportunities for trade and agriculture to supply the Forty Niners. After a short time working on a San Jose–San Francisco steamer, Henry's contacts with other German families in the Evergreen area of San Jose led him to acquire land in the Santa Clara Valley for farming. Beginning with several parcels by the bay in Mountain View, he added land in Milpitas, Evergreen, Los Altos, and off Alpine Road in San Mateo. To transport produce from the nearby farms to San Francisco and bring back supplies on scow schooners, he built a wharf (at the end of what is now Shoreline Boulevard) and developed a successful shipping business. Henry devoted his energies to managing the landing and the farms, and in 1885, received a patent for an excavator to remove dirt from dry creeks and form ditches and drains to improve irrigation.

Henry's Family and Home. Henry (b. 1829) grew up in a village near Bremen in Germany. After arriving in America, he met and married Christina Hassler (b. 1830), also from Germany. In 1867, he chose an area on the bay road near his landing as the location to build a new home. The beautiful Victorian Italianate home was the first in the area to have indoor plumbing and electricity. It provided the setting for the raising of seven children: four girls, Marie Martell, Elise Haag, Lena Askam, and Nanny McMillan, and three boys, John, Henry Andrew, and Charlie. The family was active in the community in church and political pursuits, and in musical and theatrical performances. The children and grandchildren received good educations, several attending Stanford University, UC Berkeley, Santa Clara University, and Mills College.

The House after Henry. When Henry died in 1906, his wife, Christina, inherited the house. As Christina aged, she was joined by her daughter Elise and husband, Willie Haag, and her grandson Perry Askam, the orphaned son of daughter Lena Askam. Upon Christina's death in 1919, Elise inherited the house. Perry was off to Europe several times, working with the American Field Service and the Red Cross during WWI. He became a well-known concert and light opera singer. In the 1920s to 1940s, to be near the entertainment industry, Perry lived in Los Angeles, returning to Mountain View in 1945 to help run the Rengstorff farm after his Aunt Elise's husband died. When Elise died in 1952, the house was left to



In 1979, the City of Mountain View moved the Rengstorff House from its original location on Stierlin Road to an empty field in what would eventually become Shoreline Park. This 1986 photo shows the house on the move again, this time to its permanent location near the banks of Permanente Creek. (Photo by Joe Melena, from the Mountain View Public Library Archives)

Perry. As he aged, life as a rancher became more challenging, and in 1959, he sold the house to Newhall Land Development Company and moved to an apartment on Nob Hill in San Francisco where he died in 1961. Perry Askam was the last family member to live in the house. Until the mid-1970s, the house was a rental property and then began deteriorating as squatters moved in and out. Had the house become just a rundown relic that should be torn down, or was it a precious reminder of the aesthetic and cultural history of Mountain View that should be saved?

Saving the House. Many people wanted to save the house to retain this important piece of Mountain View history. Several plans were considered to renovate, rescue, restore, donate, move, and/or tear down the property. In 1972, the house was designated a Historical Point of Interest, and in 1978, it was listed on the National Register of Historic Places, ensuring increased status, momentum, protection, and benefits. However, the location on a flood plain and in a growing industrial area determined that it should be moved. In 1979, the City of Mountain View purchased the house for $1, and soon the house was moved to a temporary site in the nearby developing regional park, Shoreline at Mountain View. Further proposals—a youth hostel, a conference center, a practice site for the Mountain View Fire Department—were considered. The Friends of "R" House, a citizen's support group, was ultimately successful in its advocacy and efforts to save the house to renew its rich architectural features and prepare it for a new purpose!



A crowd gathers in front of the Rengstorff House at the celebration of its restoration on March 2, 1991. (Photo from the Mountain View Public Library Archives)

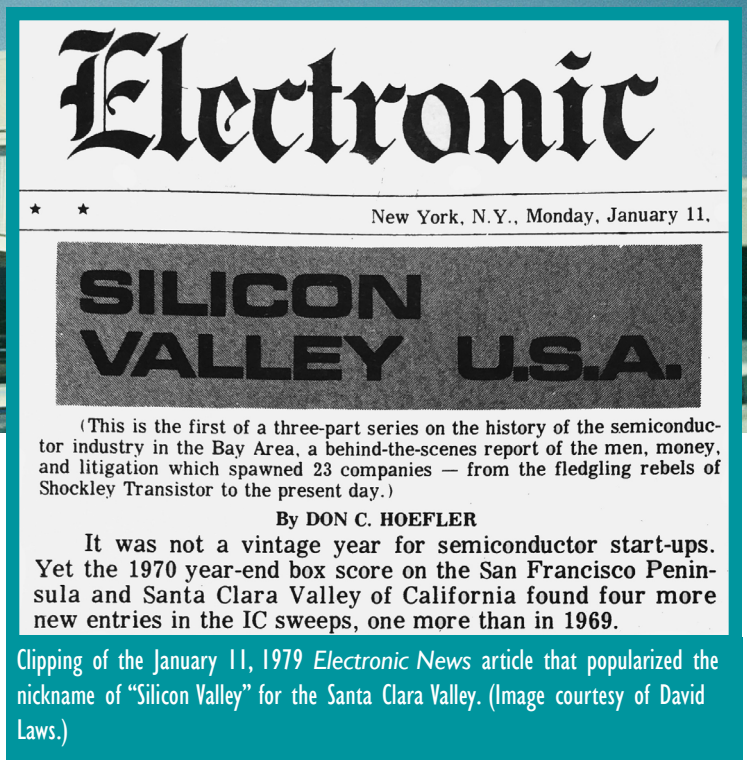
Restoration and Move. The City approved funding for the restoration; the house was moved to its present location next to Permanente Creek and restored for a cost of $1.2 million (for a video of the move, see tinyurl.com/2eje93yw). The newly incorporated nonprofit Friends of "R" House began to return the interior of the house to its original grandeur, working to decorate and furnish it as it might have looked in Henry's time, and continuing to promote awareness of the house, the Rengstorff family, and the history of Mountain View. The doors were opened to the public 30 years ago on March 2, 1991. For further information about the celebration of the 30th anniversary of the restoration and our tribute called Thirty Years of Beauty, TRANSFORMED, visit www.friendsofrhouse.org . We invite you to visit the house, once it has reopened to the public following the pandemic.

⇻ *This article was contributed by Martha Wallace, with thanks to Ginny Kaminski, Mary Boudrias, and Kristina Perino.* ⇻

Special Feature:

Mtn. View: Home to the 50-year revolution that drove Silicon Valley





Electronic

★ ★ New York, N.Y., Monday, January 11,

SILICON VALLEY U.S.A.

(This is the first of a three-part series on the history of the semiconductor industry in the Bay Area, a behind-the-scenes report of the men, money, and litigation which spawned 23 companies — from the fledgling rebels of Shockley Transistor to the present day.)

By DON C. HOEFLER

It was not a vintage year for semiconductor start-ups. Yet the 1970 year-end box score on the San Francisco Peninsula and Santa Clara Valley of California found four more new entries in the IC sweeps, one more than in 1969.

Clipping of the January 11, 1979 *Electronic News* article that popularized the nickname of "Silicon Valley" for the Santa Clara Valley. (Image courtesy of David Laws.)

By David A. Laws
Semiconductor Curator, Computer History Museum

On January 11, 1971, the industry newspaper *Electronic News* published an article on the rise of the semiconductor industry in the Santa Clara Valley. Reporter Don Hoefler titled the story "Silicon Valley USA." He thought the nickname was more appropriate than the prior "Valley of Hearts Delight," derived from the region's agricultural roots. The new name stuck.

While the name Silicon Valley is now 50 years old, a series of entrepreneurial ventures that began 50 years earlier laid the groundwork for its success. Starting early in the 1920s with radio communications, followed by microwave devices, electronic instruments, and magnetic recording, the area built a foundation of technical expertise. Coupled with the proximity to Stanford University, this capability attracted William Shockley, one of the transistor's inventors at Bell Telephone Labs, to establish Shockley Semiconductor Laboratory in Mountain View in 1956. Shockley's plan to develop silicon semiconductor devices failed when his difficult leadership style drove eight of his leading employees to defect and start their own company.

Funded by East Coast industrialist Sherman Fairchild in 1957, the group, which became known as the Traitorous Eight, developed an improved silicon transistor that found immediate application in aerospace and military defense systems. By 1960, Fairchild Semiconductor's sales exceeded $20 million—that's equivalent to nearly $200 million today. With multiple buildings scattered across Mountain View's East Whisman campus, the company was like the 1960s version of Google. Fairchild would probably have remained a successful player in the emerging semiconductor business but a new manufacturing technique called the "planar process," invented by co-founder Jean Hoerni, sparked a revolution.

Planar made better and more reliable transistors. But most importantly, it transformed the production of semiconductors from a handcrafting operation into a high-volume, electronic lithographic "printing" process that lowered costs and made them viable in new applications. Cofounder Robert Noyce realized that the technique also made it possible to interconnect multiple transistors into a complete electronic circuit on a single silicon chip. Noyce's integrated circuit (IC), or microchip, enabled smaller, faster, cheaper, and more reliable electronic systems.

In 1965, another Fairchild founder, Gordon Moore, observed that continual improvements in technology had allowed a steady increase with time in the number of components on each IC. From this data, he projected an annual growth in complexity known as "Moore's Law." Engineers across the semiconductor industry accepted the challenge of squeezing ever more transistors onto their new IC designs, leading to a self-fulfilling prophecy. This trend continues today as manufacturers routinely put billions of transistors on a chip.

Rheem Semiconductor, the first Fairchild spin-off in 1959, was followed in quick succession by founder Jay Last's Amelco Semiconductor and then by Signetics, the first stand-alone IC company. In 1972, another founder, Eugene Kleiner, started the venture capital firm of Kleiner Perkins Caufield & Byers and fellow alumnus Don Valentine started Sequoia Capital Management. Both firms funded hundreds of technology-based startups. Numerous other spin-offs, including Intel and Advanced Micro Devices (AMD), known as "Fairchildren," followed as employees left to pursue dreams of creative and financial independence.

The serendipitous combination of Hoerni's planar process, Noyce's conception of the IC, and Moore's Law created a hotbed of innovation and entrepreneurship that changed Silicon Valley from just another emerging hub of the electronics industry into a world-renowned center of innovation and entrepreneurial activity.

Membership Report

By IdaRose Sylvester
Membership Chair

Membership as of April 9, 2021

Honored Members	1
Life Members	117
Family Members	68
Single Members	79
TOTAL MEMBERSHIP	**265**

A warm welcome to our new member, Alberto M. Olmos!

Spring is time for RENEWAL!

Don't forget to renew your membership for 2021! To make our membership process easier on everyone, we're moving to an annual renewal in JANUARY for all members. Anybody who has joined or renewed after August 2020 is good until January 2022. We've also upgraded our online membership sign-up process to make it easier for you.



Have questions about your renewal status? Wish to upgrade to a lifetime membership? Drop IdaRose Sylvester a line at idarose@mountainviewhistorical.org .

You can renew online at www.mountainviewhistorical.org or mail your renewal by using the form below. Thank you for your support!

MEMBERSHIP FORM

The MVHA welcomes new members! By becoming a member, you are making a special investment in our mission to preserve and share Mountain View history with the community, conserve priceless archival materials at the History Center, and hold memorable public events throughout the year. You can also join and renew online at **www.mountainviewhistorical.org**. Please support the MVHA, and join us today!

☐ New Membership

☐ Membership Renewal

☐ Single Membership: *$15/year*

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☐ Life Membership: *$200*

Name(s): _____

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Thank you!

SPRING/SUMMER

May 2
Sunday, 1:00 p.m. to 3:00 p.m.
MVHA Spring Event & Meeting
Virtual Zoom meeting
See page one for more information!

June 9
Wednesday, 5:30 p.m. to 7:30 p.m.
MVHA Spring/Summer Board Meeting
Virtual Zoom meeting
All interested members welcome to attend! Email info@mountainviewhistorical.org for log-in.

August 1
Sunday, 1:00 p.m. to 3:00 p.m.
MVHA Summer Event & Meeting
Virtual Zoom meeting
More information in our next newsletter!

September 8
Wednesday, 5:30 p.m. to 7:30 p.m.
MVHA Summer/Fall Board Meeting
Virtual Zoom meeting
All interested members welcome to attend! Email info@mountainviewhistorical.org for log-in.

Looking Back: Photos from the Archive



This image shows the corner of Castro Street and Evelyn Avenue (then called Front Street). Both buildings still stand today, although the one on the corner has been heavily remodeled. Johnny's Cafe is now the long-time home of Vaso Azurro Ristorante, and the Post Office is now the location of Mongolian Hot Pot. After decades of operating out of various storefronts on the 100 block of Castro Street, the Mountain View Post Office relocated to a new building on the corner of Villa and Hope streets in 1960. The post office remains there today, in a structure built in 2002. A big thanks to Jim Pedersen for donating this and other images from his family albums. For more information on other items recently donated to our archives, see page 3! And if you're interested in donating materials to the archives, please contact us at info@mountainviewhistorical.org.

EST. 1954
MOUNTAIN REVIEW
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Mountain View, CA 94042
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